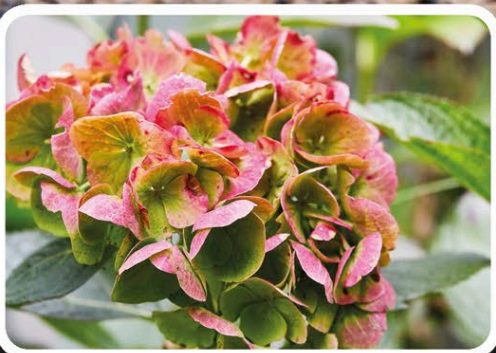


Rain is slightly acidic and dissolves limestone over time to form caves in the rock.

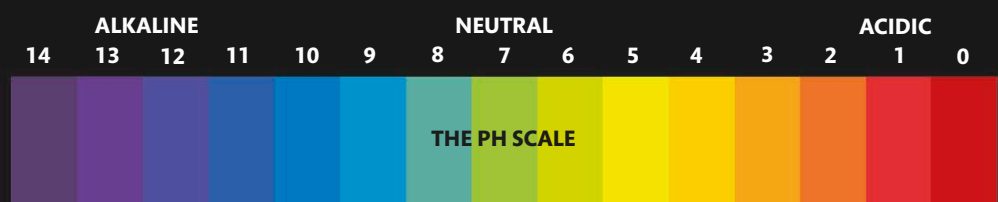


PLANTS AND PH

All plants are affected by the pH of the soil in which they are growing, and sometimes this can produce interesting effects. Hydrangeas like this one have blue flowers if they are growing in acidic soil but have pink flowers when grown in more alkaline soil.

ACIDS AND ALKALIS

Scientists describe how acidic or alkaline something is using the pH scale. On this scale, 0 is very acidic, 14 is very alkaline, and 7 is neutral. To test how acidic a substance is, scientists use indicators—substances that change color at different pH values. One of the best known is universal indicator, shown here. This is a mixture of indicators and turns different colors at different pHs.



Household bleach, along with some other cleaning products, is alkaline and has a very high pH.

The pH of pure water is 7, making it completely neutral.

Acidic foods such as vinegar and lemon juice have a low pH.